

have taken the test.

"Some of the Ivy League colleges might want you to at least sit for the SAT, but for other colleges, even just a TOEFL (Test of English as a Foreign Language) or a Duolingo English Test is good enough.

"But even if you aren't an Olympic-level athlete, there are options. If you are something like a 7.70m jumper or a girl who jumps 13.30m in the triple jump, there are a lot of mid-level NCAA Division 1 colleges that would be willing to give you a full scholarship."

While it's often been hard for Thurnhoffer to convince athletes in the past, he's seeing a change in the thought process. "Instagram has played a big role. When an athlete from India sees some of the best athletes in the world post about their college life and then go on to win medals at the Olympics, they think they can do this as well. There's a lot more awareness and with it a lot more interest," he says.

Even after they are admitted, there are challenges. "A lot of Indian athletes come from a culture where life is about eating, training, and sleeping. But that's not possible at the collegiate level. You are a student athlete and not just an athlete. You have to maintain your grade point at a certain level to be able to compete," says Tejaswin.

Heavy workload

This can be hard for some athletes who aren't used to the workload. "I'll have days when I would have been up since 5 am with a training session followed by seven hours of classes and then gym sessions in the evening. I'll be thinking at 9 pm that I can finally go to sleep when I'll remember I have an assignment due, and I'll be up till 2 am completing it," says Arjanvir, who is currently studying computer science.

The routine can be hectic, but the upside is obvious. "Currently, if I have no scholarship, it would cost me about \$65,000 a year. I'd never have had the opportunity to go to college in the USA if I didn't have a scholarship," Arjanvir says.

While he's grateful for the chance

to complete his degree, his primary goal is to improve enough as an athlete to eventually compete for India. This is the target for most athletes from India competing in the NCAA system.

"Everyone knows that competing in the NCAA is like a stepping stone for the Commonwealth Games, Asian Games, or even the Olympics. You get used to an incredibly high standard of competition. You are competing every other weekend. You have good and bad competitions, but you keep improving," says Tejaswin.

A number of athletes vouch for this. "In my first year of the indoor season, I got a chance to compete against (Kenya's) Koitatoi Kidali, who competed at the Paris Olympics in the 800m. I'd never have got the chance to compete against someone like that had I stayed in India. The kind of facilities and attention that each individual athlete gets is unheard of back in India. Your own standards and expectations get so high.

"You are part of a team of 70 or so people who are so dedicated to honing their craft and so passionate about the sport. Just being around that mindset — there isn't a word I can use to describe it. When you walk around campus, everyone knows that, okay, this is the track team.

"You know, you walk onto the track and there are 45 of you ready to go, ready to give it your all every morning. There's something about that mindset, it's just amazing. I love competing with people from all over the world," he says.

Pradeep, who was initially uncertain about applying for a scholarship overseas, now says he's advising other young Indian athletes to make the move. Tejaswin and Siddhi too have seen the interest spike. But while they are optimistic about more athletes looking to train and compete in the USA, they admit that it takes only a few bad incidents to spoil the overall picture.

A case in point is the story of **Parvej Khan (above)**, who earned a scholarship at the University of Florida where he earned a bit of a cult following in the middle-distance



scene last year before being banned after a failed dope test in India.

"Unfortunately, there is a real concern for a lot of coaches about the whole drug situation when they look to sign Indian athletes. When you have pictures of syringes in toilets going viral and after the whole Parvej situation, a lot of coaches are understandably a bit reluctant to deal with something like that," admits Thurnhoffer.

But he hopes that such concerns will fade as more Indian athletes make news for the right reasons. Pradeep hopes he will be one of those. "When I think about where I started and where I'm at, it feels like such a great opportunity. I have to grab as much of it as possible. I miss my parents, but I don't think I'll be going home for vacation or anything. My goal is eventually to compete at the Los Angeles 2028 Games, and the NCAA will give me the best chance to do that. I just want to stay here and keep this fire alive as long as I can," says Pradeep.